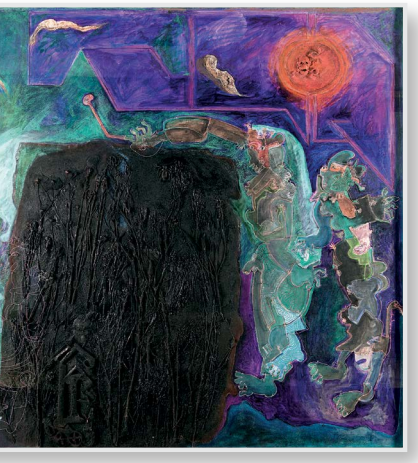




DRAWING A PARALLEL
(clockwise from top left) Amitava's 'We Have Already Gone Beyond Whatever We Have' (2011) and 'Untitled' (2021); Mohan Samant's 'Black Magician' (1996) and 'Celebration of the Dead' (1987)

title suggests. The mixed-media flourishes and the high-contrast colours, however, communicate a depth and intensity of feeling—which is the point both Amitava and Nietzsche hint at.

Pairing works by two different artists in the same physical space is not a straightforward venture. Karode describes the parallels that started emerging between Amitava and Samant's works as she began the task. "Both give so much importance to pictorial constructions. They are never loyal to a specific medium and have inclusive visions of what art is. Then there is the superficial banality of their subject matter which I find interesting. They are both interested in the question, 'What lies beneath this?'," says Karode. "I had been planning an exhibition of Amitava's works for over five years and this happened to be Samant's birth centenary year. The Samant family had gifted a set of his works to KNMA. The opportunity for a dual exhibition presented itself."

Both exhibitions portray the evolution of their respective artists' visions in very different ways. With Amitava, we get a more linear progression of his style—the abstracts, the early human figures interacting with both nature and technology in feverish modes, the mature mixed-media works where he balances evasiveness with real-world 'anchor' references to books, music and films.

Samant's (1924-2004) works, on the other hand, are a more eclectic selection from the late modernist's oeuvre. They are, Karode explains, among the artist's "more primordial works, steeped in a sense of history and man's evolution from ancient times to now". The immersive 'Black Magician' (1996; acrylic, oil, sand, straw and wire drawings on canvas) is a great example of the kind of thing Karode is talking about here, with the wire drawings adding an intriguing interplay of light and shadow.

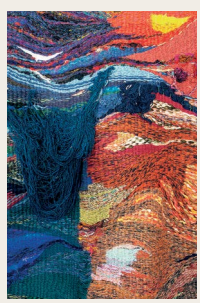
We get to see a more linear progression of **AMITAVA**'s style while **SAMANT**'s works are an eclectic selection from his oeuvre

"Like Amitava, Samant too was very interested in the mysteries of human existence," says Karode. "And magic was invented to explain things that humans couldn't. But can magic only be created by different colours? According to Samant, magic could also be created with the wire. The wire creates an illusion, a shadow-image, out of nothing." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha











FABULOUS FABRICS
(clockwise from top left) Works by artists Alka Mathur, Akshata Mokashi, Shama Pawar, Nivedita Deshpande and Rakhee Shenoy

The exhibition is on until ***September 1*** *at 47-A, Khotachi Wadi, Mumbai*

tapestries and mixed-media works that come with the loom frame. Another particularly colourful piece, 'Woven Tales of Metamorphosing', uses mixed fibres to depict a slowly transforming northeast India where a new generation creates its own identity and finds ways to coexist in peace.

Familial ties also find expressions, like Shenoy's 'Echoes of Presence', a mixed-media tapestry (including hand embroidery and print on archival canvas) that is a visual homage to her grandfather, artist G.S. Shenoy. On the other hand, Alka Mathur's works are in memory of her recently departed sister—hand-stitched mostly white-on-white assemblages using delicate muslin, inherited vintage laces, and found objects from her sister's belongings. Every piece tells a story, whether it's personal or inspired by those of artisans, like the hand weavers and embroiderers of Kutch whose struggle has been ably depicted by graphic designer and visual artist Anisha Chacko in her vibrant works, 'Threads of Resilience'. ■

–Prachi Joshi